WEEK 8 · LECTURE L2 · UNIT III

Storytelling with Data and the Ethics of Framing

From chart to decision, and how a true chart can still mislead.

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AFTER THIS LECTURE YOU SHOULD BE ABLE TO

What this lecture prepares you for

- Structure a data argument as setup, conflict and resolution (what, so what, now what).
- Choose the right chart for the message.
- Explain how framing and visual choices mislead, and how to visualize honestly.
- Apply Knaflic, Tversky and Kahneman, Heath and Heath, and Huff.

> **COURSE OUTCOMES**
> CLO 4 and CLO 5 (ethics of framing).

THREE ACTS

Setup, conflict, resolution

Setup: what?
The question and the current state.

Conflict: so what?
The gap the data reveal.

Resolution: now what?
The evidence-based action.

THE RIGHT CHART

Match the chart to the message

Message	Chart
Comparison	Bar or column
Trend over time	Line
Relationship	Scatter
Distribution	Histogram or box plot

FRAMING

Same exits, two accurate stories (illustrative)

Department	Exits (count)	Headcount	Exit rate
Operations	90	400	22.5%
Technology	17	51	33.3%
HR	8	61	13.1%

EXAM LENS

Counts point at Operations; rates point at Technology. Both are true. An honest chart says which it shows and why.

HONEST VISUALS

Three ways a true chart misleads

Cherry-picking

Showing only the period or segment that supports the story. Show limits and contrary evidence.

Misleading scales

Truncated axes, uneven intervals, 3D effects. Start bars at zero.

Hidden uncertainty

A sample figure presented as exact. Show ranges and sample sizes.

THEORY IN DEPTH · KNAFLIC (2015)

Six lessons for a data story

THE CORE IDEA

Understand the context, choose an appropriate visual, eliminate clutter, focus attention, think like a designer, tell a story.

HOW IT WORKS

Start from the audience and the action you want, then design backward to the chart.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

A practitioner guide; it rests on design experience more than experiments.

IN PRACTICE

A CHRO update needs one headline sentence, three metrics, one counter-metric and one action.

EXAM LENS

Knaflic's "big idea" (one sentence: point of view plus stakes) is a useful device for exam answers too.

THEORY IN DEPTH · TVERSKY AND KAHNEMAN (1981)

The same facts, framed differently, change choices

THE CORE IDEA

In the "Asian disease" problem, people preferred a program framed as lives saved over the same program framed as deaths.

HOW IT WORKS

Gain frames invite caution; loss frames invite risk-taking. The frame shifts the reference point.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Effect sizes vary, and expert audiences are not immune.

IN PRACTICE

"79% of staff stayed" and "21% of staff left" are the same fact but invite different Board responses.

EXAM LENS

Use framing to discuss the ethics of how HR presents data, not just its accuracy.

THEORY IN DEPTH · HEATH AND HEATH (2007)

Ideas stick when they are simple and concrete

THE CORE IDEA

SUCCESs: Simple, Unexpected, Concrete, Credible, Emotional, Stories.

HOW IT WORKS

A concrete case and an unexpected fact carry an abstract number into memory.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Stickiness serves bad ideas too; it is a tool, not a test of truth.

IN PRACTICE

One concrete employee story can make an abstract completion gap memorable for a Board.

EXAM LENS

Pair stickiness with honesty: a memorable story must still be representative.

THEORY IN DEPTH · HUFF (1954)

How to lie with statistics

THE CORE IDEA

A classic catalogue of tricks: biased samples, well-chosen averages, missing figures, gee-whiz graphs.

HOW IT WORKS

Ask: who says so, how do they know, what is missing, did somebody change the subject, does it make sense?

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Old examples, but the five questions remain a sound checklist.

IN PRACTICE

Apply Huff's five questions to every vendor claim about adoption or ROI.

EXAM LENS

Huff's questions are a ready-made structure for critically evaluating any statistic in an exam case.

PRACTICE FOR THE END-TERM EXAMINATION

Questions to rehearse

"A true chart can still mislead." Discuss with reference to framing effects and honest visualization principles. **20 marks**

A strong answer: uses Tversky and Kahneman; counts versus rates; scales and uncertainty; Huff's questions; proposes standards.

Using Knaflic and Heath and Heath, explain how HR should present an analytics finding to a Board, and the ethical limits of persuasive presentation. **20 marks**

A strong answer: covers the three acts and six lessons; stickiness; balances persuasion against representativeness and honesty.

Apply Huff's five questions to a vendor claim that its app "raised engagement by 30%". **10 marks**

A strong answer: applies each question concretely.

CARRY THESE INTO THE EXAMINATION

Three things to remember

1. **Every data story needs what, so what and now what**
2. **Say whether you show counts or rates, and why**
3. **An honest chart shows its limits**

SET READINGS · FROM THE LESSON PLAN

Read for this lecture

- Angrave, D., et al. (2016). HR and analytics: Why HR is set to fail the big data challenge. *HRMJ, 26*(1), 1–11.
- Knaflic, C. N. (2015). *Storytelling with Data*.

COMPANION

Each set reading is explained in the matching Unit Reader on rksingh.tech/materials.

Sources for this lecture

Works named on the slides of this lecture. They are background sources, not set readings.

Angrave, D., Charlwood, A., Kirkpatrick, I., Lawrence, M., & Stuart, M. (2016). HR and analytics: Why HR is set to fail the big data challenge. *Human Resource Management Journal, 26*(1), 1–11. https://doi.org/10.1111/1748-8583.12090

Heath, C., & Heath, D. (2007). *Made to stick: Why some ideas survive and others die*. Random House.

Huff, D. (1954). *How to lie with statistics*. W. W. Norton.

Knaflic, C. N. (2015). *Storytelling with data: A data visualization guide for business professionals*. Wiley.

Tversky, A., & Kahneman, D. (1981). The framing of decisions and the psychology of choice. *Science, 211*(4481), 453–458. https://doi.org/10.1126/science.7455683